

ANTICIPATIONS

Notes that arrive early — creating forward motion and the characteristic feeling of groove

WHAT IS AN ANTICIPATION?

An anticipation = a note on an UPBEAT with NO NOTE on the following downbeat

The anticipated note **FEELS** like it's on the next downbeat — but it arrived early.

Key distinction: not every upbeat note is an anticipation — only if **no note follows on the NEXT beat**.

An anticipation is always a **STOP** — the phrase lands on the upbeat, then the next downbeat is empty.

REGULAR ANTICIPATION — 1/8 NOTE EARLY

BEFORE (DULL)



Note on beat 3 — lands heavy, expected



AFTER (ANTICIPATED)



Moved to "and of 2" — arrived 1/8 note early

Effect:

Creates **forward motion**. The listener's body leans toward beat 3 but the note already arrived. Creates excitement and energy. Used in virtually every groove-based genre.

QUARTER NOTE ANTICIPATION — 1/4 NOTE EARLY (THE STRONGEST)

ONLY POSSIBLE FROM BEAT 4 → BEAT 1 OF THE NEXT MEASURE

BEFORE

MEASURE 1



Note on beat 1 of measure 2 — predictable entrance

MEASURE 2



AFTER — QUARTER NOTE ANTICIPATION

MEASURE 1



Moved to "and of 4" — 2 positions early. Beat 1 of M2 is now empty.

MEASURE 2



Used in: "Beautiful Day" — U2 piano intro · "Say" — John Mayer kick drum · "I'm Every Woman" — Whitney Houston vocal entrance

NOT ALL UPBEATS ARE ANTICIPATIONS — KEY DISTINCTION

✓ IS AN ANTICIPATION



Note on "and 1", **nothing on beat 2** → this IS an anticipation. The note stops on the upbeat.

✗ NOT AN ANTICIPATION



Note on "and 1", **followed by beat 2** → NOT an anticipation. It's just an upbeat note passing through.

"I'm Every Woman" — Whitney Houston

The very first vocal note is an anticipation — arrives on the upbeat before beat 1. Sets the groove from the first breath.

"Get Up" — James Brown

The guitar part anticipates beat 3 consistently throughout. Signature James Brown upbeat-heavy feel.

"Beautiful Day" — U2

Quarter note anticipation in the piano. Beat 1 of every second measure is empty — arrived early from "and of 4." The strongest anticipation type.